

# **Rural Health Transformation Program Advisory Council – August 20, 2026**



# Stevens Amendment

This project supported by the Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (CMS) of the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services (HHS) as part of a financial assistance award totaling \$208,374,447.57 with 100 percent funded by CMS/HHS. The contents are those of the author(s) and do not necessarily represent the official views of, nor an endorsement, by CMS/HHS, or the U.S. Government.



# Agenda

- Call to Order / Roll Call
- Approval of Agenda
- Items for Discussion
  - Purpose and role of RHTP Advisory Council
  - Office of Rural Health Transformation and Sustainability Update
  - Rural Health Transformation Program – CMS Report Review
  - 2026 Meeting Schedule (not yet confirmed; will be distributed upon confirmation)
- Public Comment Period
  - In-person comments
  - Electronic comments
- Consideration of any other matters that may come before the Council
- Adjournment

The top corners of the slide feature decorative geometric patterns. These patterns consist of overlapping triangles and quadrilaterals in shades of dark blue, teal, and a lighter blue-grey, creating a modern, abstract look.

# Call to Order

## Roll Call



# Approval of Agenda

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# Items for Discussion

# RHTP Advisory Council Purpose

- LA Rural Health Transformation Program Advisory Council established within the Office of Rural health Transformation and Sustainability through Governor Landry Executive Order Number JML 26-032
- Composed of 11 members appointed by the Governor
  - Secretary of LDH or designee, chair
  - Secretary of La Works or designee
  - President of La Community Technology College or designee
  - Executive Director Louisiana Rural Hospital Coalition or designee
  - President La Independent Pharmacies Association or designee
  - Chair House Health / Welfare or designee
  - Chair Senate Health / Welfare or designee
  - Four at large members with demonstrated experience or active involvement in rural healthcare



# RHTP Advisory Council Role

- Actively participate and engage in work of the Council
- Review Quarterly and annual grant reports submitted to CMS
- Provide strategic guidance and stakeholder engagement on all reporting requirements
- Work to ensure that rural health transformation initiatives align with statewide priorities, reflect the needs of local communities, and advance sustainable, data-informed improvements in care delivery.
- Support transparency, accountability, and coordination in the implementation of rural health initiatives and grant investments



# ORHTS Updates





# RHTP MISSION & ROLE

- Enhance sustainability of rural healthcare providers while ensuring Louisiana's 1.1 million rural residents, particularly those with chronic and behavioral health needs, can access high-quality care close to home.
- Build partnerships across rural communities with all stakeholders.
- Re-envision LDH role in rural health as a facilitator for collaboration.



*Rural Health Transformation Task Force meeting*

# Why are we here?

- Louisiana awarded \$208,374,448 for Budget Period 1 of Rural Health Transformation Grant.
- Estimated \$1.4 billion over 5 years.
- One of the top awards in the nation.

Every rural Louisianian deserves the same high-quality health and health care as anyone else in our state. Through a five-year investment, we are building sustainable access to care so rural communities can thrive – today and for generations to come.



# State Policy Actions in Application

- **SNAP waivers** – La: 100 points for USDA approved state waiver prohibiting purchase of non-nutritious items in SNAP
- **Nutrition and Continuing Medical Education** – La: 100 points for legislative requirement in place
- **Certificate of Need** – La: 50/100 points based on Cicero Institute Findings as we have some requirements in place
- **Licensure Compacts** – Data they use showing La with 100/100 points in areas of physician, nurse, and EMS, but 0/100 points for psychology and physician assistant; plan to share universal licensure passed in 2024 session as evidence for full points
- **Scope of Practice** – La: 50/100 points for physician assistant and nurse practitioner and 0/100 points for pharmacist and dental hygienist
- **Short Term Limited Duration Insurance** – full points as we mirror federal practice on this
- **Remote Care Services** – La with partial points for this and we do include pilots in initiatives
- **Presidential Fitness** – Governor signed executive order prior to application to maximize points



# Key ORHTS Activities Completed

## Administrative Tasks

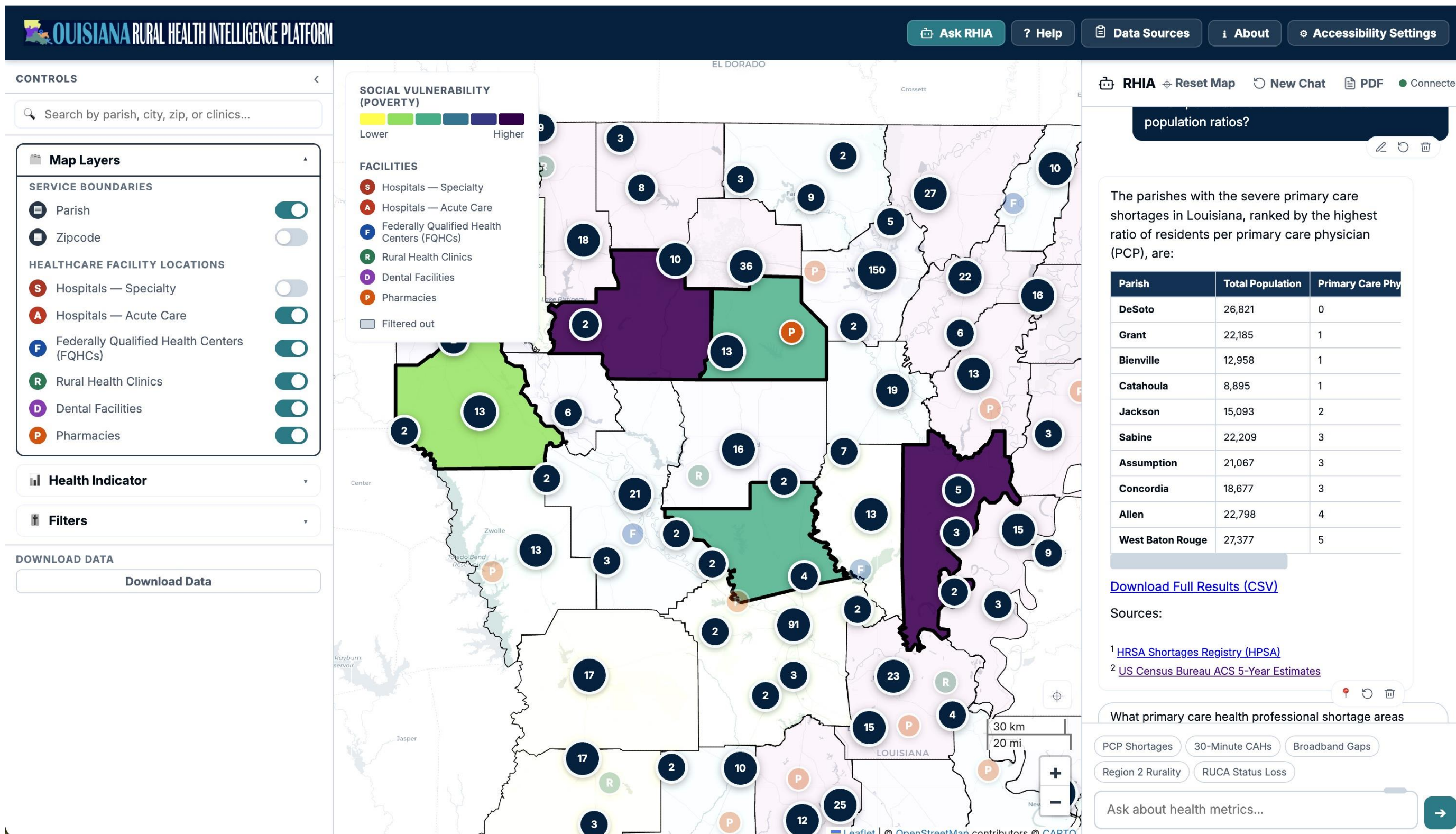
- Created new office established through Executive Order (16 Job Appointment positions)
- Shifted Health Care Access Division / State Office of Rural Health to ORHTS
- Secured budget authority for expenditure of RHTP funds
- Established rural definition for Budget Year 1 funding

## Governance Tasks

- Established ORHTS Executive Management Team
- Created LDH Executive Team and RHTP Steering Committee
- Worked with Governor's Office on standing up RHTP Advisory Council



# Rural Definition / Needs Assessment: RHTLA.Net



## Public

- Rurality Definition
- Needs assessment
- Initiative tracker
- Resources and providers

## Internal

- Screening for eligibility
- Tracking and reporting
- Alignment with gaps
- Strategy and planning

## Purpose

- Awareness
- Data Aggregation across public, private and LDH
- Ease of access
- External validation
- Academic partnership

# Key ORHTS Activities Completed

## Stakeholder Engagement

- Established dedicated e-mail address for correspondence ([Ruralhealthtransformation@la.gov](mailto:Ruralhealthtransformation@la.gov))
- Hold monthly ORHTS webinars – first Thursday of every month, 9 – 10 AM CT
- Multiple round table meetings on identified topic areas bringing in rural health providers and subject matter experts
- Individual meetings with providers, vendors, and leaders in rural health care
- ORHTS team presented information / updates to health care association meetings, forums, and symposiums
- Executive Director and Deputy Director requested to speak at national conferences / summits to represent Louisiana RHTP



# Key ORHTS Activities Completed

## CMS Engagement

- Selected as first state to participate in the CMS State Site Visits – held April 2026
- Completed required updates to Project Narrative and Budget Narrative to meet CMS guidelines and ongoing technical assistance
- Meet bi-weekly with project officer and monthly with grants management officer
- Participated in annual RHTP summit in Baltimore
- Preparation for annual reporting due August 31, 2026

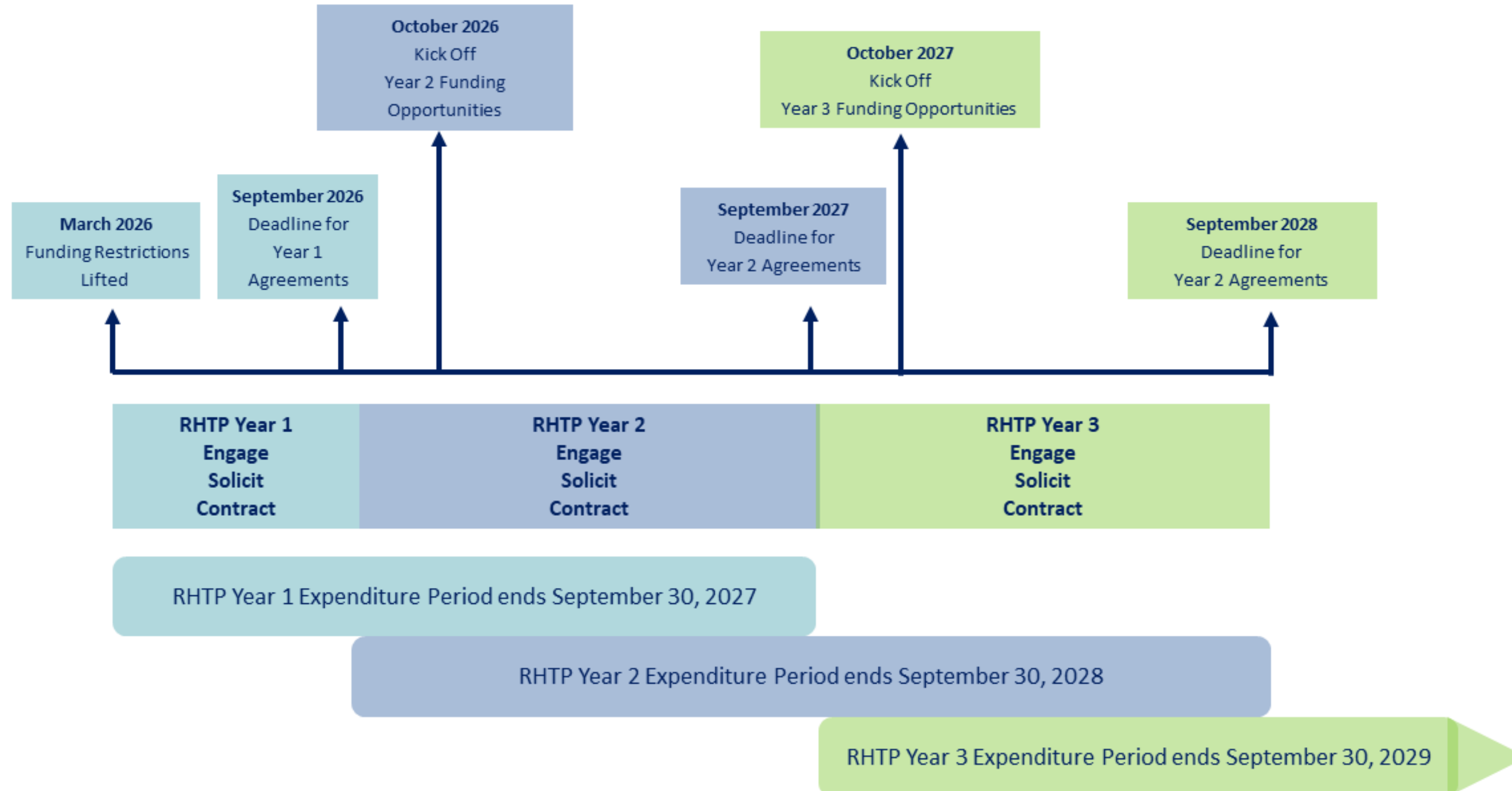
# Key ORHTS Activities Completed

## Funding / Contracting

- Opened 8 competitive funding opportunities for sub-grants; created scoring rubric – awards in process
- 5 funding opportunities for specialized expertise partnerships
- 12 funding opportunities for expedited partnerships
- Next Advisory Council meeting agenda to include a complete list of obligated funds by entity type



# RHTP Funding Cycle



# Budget Year 1 Applications

| Activity                            | # Received | Projected BY 1 Funding | Anticipated Announcement |
|-------------------------------------|------------|------------------------|--------------------------|
| Rural Clinician Credit Bank         | 136        | \$10 million           | Mid August               |
| Capital Improvement Program         | 160        | \$41.60 million        | Late August              |
| Telehealth                          | 79         | \$4.71 million         | Late August              |
| Collaborative Provider Model        | 37         | \$3 million            | Early September          |
| Alternative Payment Model           | 31         | \$30 million           | Early September          |
| Care conveners / navigation network | 25         | \$3.5 million          | Mid September            |
| Food is Medicine                    | 37         | \$2.7 million          | Mid September            |

# Exciting Opportunities / Early Wins

- Creating forum for engagement with rural providers
- Workforce
  - Connections and partnerships between universities / colleges and rural facilities
  - Data analysis and identification of trends at facilities through RCCB
  - Development of governance structures at facilities to increase focus
- Technology / Innovative Care
  - Partnership with LED on Rural Tech Catalyst Fund
  - Interest in platforms to promote participation in VBC and inter-operability and recognized need for infrastructure
  - Quality and Value Convention good working session for LDH priorities and engagement with rural providers



# Planned Engagement

- Participation in Budget Year 2 Planning
  - Developing think tanks, round table discussions, and listening sessions
- Regional Site Visits: Town Hall meetings, rural facility tours, targeted engagement with providers
  - 2026 / 2027 Calendar in development
- List Serve in development
- ORHTS team will participate in any event invited to share information, network, and learn from rural communities
- Next monthly webinar will be on Thursday, September 3, 2026, 9 – 10 AM CT
- Next Advisory Council meeting: Thursday, November 5, 2026; House Committee Room 3; 9 – 11 AM CT



# RHTP – CMS Report Review





# CMS Reporting Timelines

- Budget Year 1 Annual Report: Due 8/31/2026
  - Checkpoint by initiative: Summary, metrics, number served, evidence
  - State Policy Action commitments: Evidence
  - Use of Funds reporting: obligated / spent by funding bucket and type of entity
  - Success, Sustainability, and Rural Definition
- NCC Year 2 Continuation Request: Due 8/31/2026
  - Updated grant forms
  - Project narrative and budget narrative updates for Year 2 funding request
- Quarterly Report: Due 11/29/2026 – Include all obligated funds up to 10/30
- Next Advisory Council meeting to include review of full report





# **Public Comment Period**

## **In-Person Comments**



# **Public Comment Period Electronic Comments**





**Consideration of any other  
matters that may come  
before the Council**

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# Adjournment